The report suggested: ‘In our opinion, the Assam Rifles are not in a position to defend the frontier against mass aggression and the word “Security” instead of “Defence” would better define their duty. We consider also that the “internal border” should not include the border with Pakistan as far as the Assam Rifles are concerned.” The report then went on to suggest that “an expansion and the concentration and redeployment of the Assam Rifles are necessary for more effective occupation of the border area’.

By the mid-1950s, the Assam Rifles, in its various avatars, had more or less completed a task which had taken it more than 120 years. It had, by implementing first British India’s and then independent India’s Forward Policy (not to be confused with Nehru’s subsequent Forward Policy), more or less consolidated the entire northeastern region. In the NEFA sector alone, new Assam Rifles posts were established all along the McMahon Line (the boundary between Tibet and India as part of the Simla Agreement, 1914) with extensive patrolling of the border areas. The Government of India believed that the Chinese would not actually go to war with India on the issue of the McMahon Line, and expected that the International Border would stabilize along the Line of Actual Control, that is, the border established by the presence of troops. By then, twenty-four platoons of Assam Rifles were deployed in NEFA, manning posts all along the watershed: Gemchram (13,779 feet), Taksing (10,500 feet), Dom-la (17,060 feet), Karbo (11,811 feet), Dembuen (11,800 feet), Malinye (9,842 feet) Mipidon (5,577 feet) and Jachap (9,186 feet). No government could have asked for more, for these hardy soldiers had always performed way beyond expectation.

In the Western Sector, the IB and the army set up posts in most areas except for Lingzi Tang, Aksai Chin, the Soda and the Depsang Plains as these regions were almost completely uninhabited and nearly inaccessible. Because of its very nature and sheer expanse, the Ladakh region had huge gaps between posts. So an elaborate plan to patrol the various sectors was worked out with the army. At that point, there were hardly any troops in Eastern Ladakh, only a single infantry battalion with its headquarters in Karu was looking after the area up to Chushul.

THE TAWANG SALIENT AND THE TAGIN MURDERS